SPELLSHOT — Lore Codex: The Sundering of the Ley

Editorial note: this document exists to justify two structural facts of the game in-fiction — that an Element unlock delivers M1, Primary Ability, and Passive as a single indivisible bundle, and that Techniques form a separate, freely mixable pool drawn from all eight Elements. A third section, "The Unfound Cores," extends this same logic to justify future post-launch Elements as combinations of the original eight rather than as separate discoveries. The prose below is written as an in-world text — a codex entry a scholar within SPELLSHOT's world might have written — and may be adapted directly into flavor text, loading screens, or Section 2 of the Design Manual.

I. The Sundering

It is recorded, in every account that survives, that there was once a single current beneath the world: the Ley, unbroken and entire, from which all elemental force descended before it had cause to divide. No fire existed apart from ice, no lightning apart from stone. There was only the Ley, whole, and the world above it, ignorant of what it rested upon.

What ended this unity is disputed. The eastern chronicles name it a war between powers no longer remembered; the western name it a theft; the priesthoods of the Hub name it a correction visited upon the world by the Ley itself, for reasons it did not trouble to explain. The event itself, whatever its cause, is called by all the same name: the Sundering.

In that instant, the Ley did not vanish. It broke — cleanly, into eight complete and self-sufficient fragments, each retaining the whole character of the source from which it came. These are the Cores: Pyro, Cryo, Voltaic, Terra, Zephyr, Umbra, Radiant, and Toxin. Each is entire unto itself, lacking nothing, owing nothing to the others.

But the Sundering did not stop at eight. Around each Core, in the violence of its parting, lesser fragments were cast outward across the world — pieces too small and too incomplete to stand as Cores in their own right. These are known as Echoes, and they number, by even the most conservative reckoning, in the thousands.

II. The Bond

A Core does not instruct. It does not apprentice a supplicant over years, nor grant its power by degrees. A Core chooses, and having chosen, it binds itself to the one it has chosen entirely and at once. This binding is called Attunement, and it is permanent.

What passes to the Duelist in Attunement is not a set of techniques to be learned separately, for the Core does not conceive of itself in parts. A Core is a single temperament of power, and what a Duelist receives — the manner of their basic strike, the shape of their signature ability, the quiet advantage that follows them without their willing it — are not three gifts but three expressions of one nature, no more separable from each other than a person's gait, their voice, and their bearing might be separated and distributed to different owners. To take Pyro's strike without Pyro's temperament would not be to take a smaller gift; it would be to take nothing coherent at all.

For this reason, no Duelist has ever divided a Core, and no Duelist has ever held more than one. It is not forbidden; it has simply never been achieved, for a Core does not share the space of its binding, and a Duelist's capacity for Attunement, whatever its true nature, has never been observed to exceed one bond at a time.

III. The Echoes

The Echoes are of a different order entirely. Too fragmentary to bind wholly with anyone, they may nonetheless be found, studied, and carried — and unlike a Core, an Echo does not demand exclusivity. Any Duelist, regardless of the Core to which they are bound, may learn to carry an Echo, for what passes between an Echo and its bearer is not a binding of nature but a loan of function: a manner of movement, a means of defense, a singular and decisive act reserved for the moment it is needed most.

It follows, then, that a Duelist bound to Voltaic may carry an Echo of Cryo's making, and another of Terra's, without contradiction — for they have not divided their loyalty to their Core; they have merely gathered, as any capable Duelist must, the loose inheritance the Sundering scattered across the world for anyone diligent enough to claim it. A Duelist arrayed in the borrowed light of several Cores is not an anomaly to be explained away. It is, in fact, the truest picture of what every Duelist becomes with time and practice — one nature, wholly their own, adorned with fragments of every other nature they have proven worthy to carry.

IV. The Duelist

A Duelist is neither chosen by prophecy nor risen through inheritance. The Ley's selection, insofar as it can be understood at all, appears indifferent to lineage, station, or merit foreseen — it simply acts, and one who was ordinary the day before wakes bound to a Core the day after, with no further explanation offered.

What a Duelist does with this binding is a matter of standing among their own kind alone. Duels are not fought in war, nor for territory, nor for any purpose beyond the proving of a Bond against another's — a custom closer to trial than to conflict, by which a Duelist's mastery of

their Core, and the quality of the Echoes they have gathered, may be measured and made known. It is through this repeated proving, accumulated over seasons, that a Duelist may in time be named Ascendant — a rank at which the wider world ceases to ask which Core a Duelist carries, and asks instead only whether they are among the few the Cores themselves seem to have favored.

V. The Unfound Cores

It is a matter of settled record that eight Cores, and eight alone, were born of the Sundering. It does not follow, however, that eight is the whole and final number of Cores the world will ever know.

In the ages since the Sundering, scattered Echoes — cast far from their origin and left long undisturbed — have in certain places drifted together. Where an Echo of one Core's making has come to rest for centuries beside an Echo of another's, under conditions no scholar has yet fully accounted for, the two have on rare occasion ceased to behave as loose fragments altogether, and fused. What results is not a copy of either parent Core, nor a mere combination of their traits, but something new entire — a Core in its own right, complete and self-sufficient exactly as the original eight are, yet born of two natures rather than one.

These fused Cores are called the Unfound, not because they do not exist, but because they have not yet been located, and because — until a Duelist first Attunes to one and Attunement makes its nature known — the world cannot say with certainty what any given Unfound Core will be. What can be said with certainty is only this: an Unfound Core, wherever and whenever it is discovered, will carry the inherited character of two or more of the original eight, expressed as something the world has not previously seen. It is by this same principle that every Unfound Core, once bound, is understood to seed further Echoes of its own — for having become whole, it sunders its own excess outward precisely as the original eight once did, and the world's stock of loose fragments grows by exactly as much as its stock of Cores does.

It is for this reason the scholars of the Hub maintain, against those who insist the world's magic is a finite and dwindling inheritance, that the Ley has not stopped becoming. It has only slowed.

Loading screen or store blurb (formal register):

The Ley was whole, once, before it broke into eight Cores and scattered a thousand lesser fragments across the world. You are bound to one Core, wholly and permanently — the rest you carry into a duel has been gathered, fragment by fragment, from the wreckage the Sundering left behind. Attune. Prove your Bond. And watch, in time, for what the broken pieces of the old Ley may yet become.